

NO ENTRY

By deporting Sharif back to Jeddah, Musharraf punctured his comeback bid but in doing so embarked on a perilous confrontational approach.

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

It had been billed as the "return of the prodigal", "history in the making", and even "the beginning of the revolution". A million-strong crowd was to have received exiled former premier Nawaz Sharif at the Islamabad airport, his arrival marking a triumphant return to his country after seven-and-a-half years in political wilderness. It was to be the last nail in the coffin of President General Pervez Musharraf's military-led regime and the birth of a people's movement for democracy. Of course, none of this actually happened.

As it turned out, Sharif's homecoming on September 10 was a damp squib and played more like a farce from the beginning to the end. If anything, it only demonstrated how far Pakistan's politicians still had to go for their words to match their deeds. Or their hopes to match the bitter realities on the ground.

Sharif stayed on Pakistani soil for barely three and a half hours after his Pakistan International Airlines flight touched down at Islamabad airport. With hopes of a massive reception vapourising and his ragtag supporters unable to break a fierce five-kilometre government cordon around the airport or get through to their leader—cell phones had been jammed around the airport—the befuddled and isolated former prime minister was soon bundled back into a plane bound for Jeddah, beginning what is likely to be another three-year stint in the Saudi kingdom. And given the Saudi royalty's annoyance at his violation of an agreement they had brokered and guaranteed, his exile this time round will, in all probability, be considerably harsher than the last time.

In retrospect, the signs had been there all along that things would not go quite the way Sharif had been hoping for. He had been living in comfortable exile for the past two years in London, since being allowed to leave

A FARCE: Sharif landed at the Islamabad airport only to be packed off again



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